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From the editor-in-chief

Indian politicians have the longest shelf life. Our politics is still dominated by people who would have been put out to pasture long ago in any other profession. Regardless of their tenacity or position or stature and whether they realise it or not, all politicians have an expiry date. As history has shown, this is true for the greatest of statesmen. The smart ones realise it in time and leave gracefully; others face ignoble ejection. Unfortunately, BJP stalwart Lal Krishna Advani, 82, has left it too late. He now faces a sad end to a formidable political career. He has, with one comparatively brief interruption, been the party's maximum leader in recent years and his partnership with A.B. Vajpayee transformed the BJP from a minor player into a credible national political force.

Checking our archives, I discover that INDIA TODAY has done 41 cover stories featuring Advani, a tribute to his stature, longevity and impact on the country's politics and policies. Yet, the signs that his political career was in jeopardy have been evident for some time. Robbed of Vajpayee's support, his vulnerability was exposed in 2005 after his controversial statement on Jinnah.

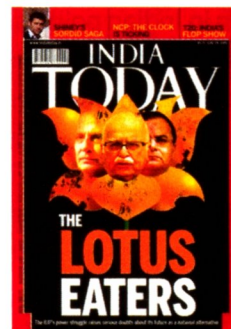
Abandoned by his party and forced to quit as its president, he revived his career on the basis of his stature and the party's electoral requirements but the subsequent Lok Sabha defeat was his death knell to which he turned a deaf ear.

Back in June I had written: "The crisis (in the BJP) is about the clash between the Old Guard and the New. It is clear that their target is Advani and the erosion of his authority suggests that the revolt in the party could gather steam if corrective measures are not taken." They weren't. Today, as the BJP faces its biggest existential crisis, he again stands alone amidst the storm of allegations, a forlorn figure whose studied silence on the crisis and factional battles in the party is really a scream of anguish. It is a tragic moment in Indian politics. This is the man who has laboured the hardest and journeyed the most to build the party. The individual tragedy of L.K. Advani is more engrossing than the drama in the party. Today, its tallest leader whose political life is almost as old as Independent India, has become the singular hurdle to the BJP's future. There is little doubt that he has to go; the only question is when and how. It's an inglorious end to a journey that paralleled the evolution of BJP since its official inception in 1980.

Our cover story looks at the man and the moment, and analyses the key question: How has the great organisation man, the builder of the BJP, become its greatest burden? We retrace the mistakes he made and look at who will be his likely successors. Advani's tragedy also mirrors the BJP's tragedy, a party that, without a guiding moral force like Vajpayee, seems directionless, lacking leadership and confused about its ideology. We also examine the role of the RSS as arbiter and peacemaker and whether it can provide direction and reunite the warring factions of the BJP.

India needs a strong opposition to keep the ruling party accountable and it would be sad if one man's failings were to deny Indian democracy that.

(Aroon Purie)



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